keeping, maintenance, senior-friendly meal options, are now standard in senior living homes.

This could mean a higher monthly maintenance fee compared to regular societies where the charge is between Rs 2 and Rs 5 per square foot. The maintenance fee at Antara Dehradun, by contrast, is Rs 27 per sq. ft, adding up to between Rs 47,000 and Rs 75,000 plus taxes, depending on apartment size. Antara Noida is relatively cheaper, charging Rs 6 to Rs 8 per sq. ft for maintenance, totalling an all-inclusive Rs 13,000 to Rs 22,000 (see *A Space of Their Own*).

Back in 2018, the CII Senior Care Industry Report projected the estimated demand for senior housing at around 300,000, with the supply limited to 90 communities and 20,000 units. The demand has only grown since. Antara, therefore, plans to invest Rs 200 crore in the next 4-5 years to build 4,500 apartments across Bengaluru, Hyderabad, Chennai, Pune, Goa and Chandigarh. Similarly, Ashiana Housing, which will be closing this fiscal with 500 units, plans to increase its sales to 900 units per year over the next three years. "A 30-40 per cent growth for senior living players is not unusual, and most of them are aiming for these growth numbers," says Ashiana JMD Gupta, who is also the co-founder and chairman of the Association of Senior Living India (ASLI).

At Your Service

Though they started with offering independent homes, over time, players such as CovaiCare, Ashiana, Antara and others expanded to provide assisted care to their elderly residents according to their varying needs. "As a service provider, if your residents develop specific conditions, you cannot shy away from assisting them in managing their ailments," says Colonel Achal Sridharan, founder & MD of CovaiCare, which currently serves



COURTESY REVATHI BHASKER



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Founder and Managing Director, CovaiCare

1,000 residents in South India.

The reason is not far to seek. Indians are living longer, with the average lifespan increasing from 47.7 years in 1970 to 69.6 years in 2020, per World Health Organization data. The onset of many diseases common among the elderly take root in middle age, be it diabetes, hypertension, cardiac ailments, bone and joint issues or sight and hearing, says Dr Rajinder Kumar Singal, principal director & head of the department of internal medicine at the BLK-Max Super Speciality Hospital in Delhi. Consequently, the number of years individuals now require support to manage their physical ailments has also risen.

It is this need that niche players such as the Chennai-based Athulya Assisted Living are answering, with eight centres across Chennai, Kochi, Bengaluru and Coimbatore. The assisted living segment is divided into four broad categories, explains Dr Karthik Narayan, its managing direc-